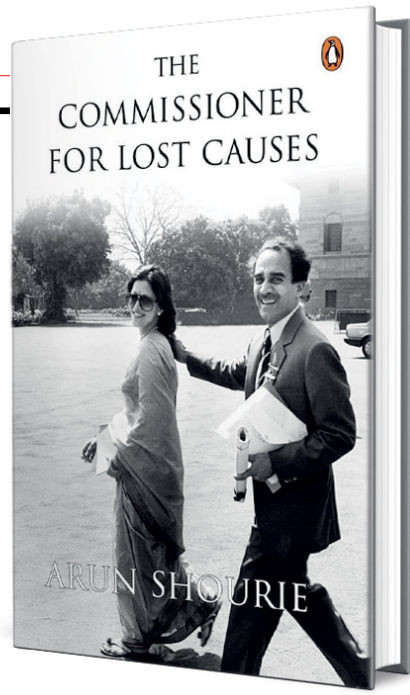


BOOK REVIEW

A MAVERICK'S TALE

By Sunil Sethi

News consumers in the digital age may chiefly remember Arun Shourie for his corpus of books on subjects ranging from political ideology, religion and law to personal memoir and his tenure as a forward-thinking disinvestment minister in the Atal Bihari Vajpayee government. But a few still recall his trail-blazing innings as editor-activist of *The Indian Express* that made him a household name in the 1970s and 1980s. Relocating to India from his World Bank job due to his son's illness, Shourie's passionate critique of Indira Gandhi's Emergency regime coincided with the fierce opposition mounted by press baron Ramnath Goenka, owner of the *Express*.

Together, they forged a partnership that ineluctably changed the tenor of journalism in that turbulent time. An implacable defender of press freedoms, Goenka had doting epithets for Shourie—"my racehorse" was a favourite. He also wanted to put up a sign reading "The Commissioner for Lost Causes" outside his cabin—that is the source of this book's clunky title.

A series of searing, relentless exposés made the paper's name. Among them were the plight of 85,000 undertrials, including women and children, rotting for years in jails and, even more horrifyingly, suspects in Bihar who had acid poured into their eyes by the police. Scoops such as the "Bhagalpur blindings" shook the nation and became bywords of New Journalism. As sensational was the case of Kamla, an abandoned young woman who an enterprising *Express* reporter "purchased" for Rs 2,300 in 1981 as evidence of the slave trade in Madhya Pradesh. The public outrage and legal fallout were enormous—playwright Vijay Tendulkar wrote a play about the case, and a film called *Kamla* was made.

Shourie describes at copious length how he demolished newsroom hierarchies, backing rookie reporters and outstation correspondents to zealously pursue stories and sustain lengthy follow-ups in courts. "There is no Opposition. There is just one newspaper," said Rajiv Gandhi at the height of the Bofors scandal, and the *Express* pressed on, perilously, resisting government and trade union pressure to fall in line.

Some of the opposition came from within. Shourie's peers often took a dim view of the goings-on. B.G. Verghese called him "a stormy petrel, a maverick...and ever so long-winded". S. Nihal Singh said he "assumed the airs of a prima donna" and "exploited his proximity to Goenka to terrorise reporters and sub-editors". Shourie gave as good as he got, dubbing old-school editors as members of the "Indian Journalists Service".

Brevity is not Shourie's strong suit. This 600-page volume, with exhaustive—often exhausting—footnotes, English translation of Hindi conversations and labyrinthine court proceedings, is a record of Shourie-led campaigns against political corruption and skulduggery. Some were remarkable, such as the crusade against Maharashtra chief minister A.R. Antulay's money-making trusts that effectively finished off this Congress leader's political career; or the challenge to the draconian anti-press defamation bills floated by the Bihar, and later the Rajiv Gandhi, governments. Others, such as the convoluted progression of the Bofors investigation, or the story of the government being bilked of nearly $200 million by a Hong Kong company in the Kuo oil contract, petered out inconclusively. However, their retelling takes 65 and 30 pages, respectively.

And when the paper failed to publish his story (for the canny Goenka was not going to risk his paper's survival and dismissed him), Shourie lived up to the derogatory label of "pamphleteer" by distributing cyclostyled sheets to MPs.

THE COMMISSIONER FOR LOST CAUSES
by Arun Shourie
PENGUIN
₹999, 616 pages

There are plenty of juicy anecdotes and first-hand encounters here of the many figures who fashioned India's late 20th century political landscape but none as compelling as the portrait of the larger-than-life Goenka—complex, mercurial and colourful—who "could abuse fluently in thirteen languages". He dominates the book, a many-tentacled leviathan of networking energy. There are also some revealing missives, for instance, a grovelling letter from Justice P.N. Bhagwati to Indira Gandhi, comparing her return to power as "the reddish glow of the rising sun".

Of Shourie's writing, the political philosopher Martha Nussbaum said that it "all has the same mocking, superior tone". His didactic prescription for journalists, headlined 'Rules of Thumb', is a 39-point, eight-page advisory. But it omits one essential commandment—even the best editors need a thorough edit. ■

Sunil Sethi *is a veteran journalist, columnist and television presenter*